

Five Hours Apart

A hypothetical, in three parts

DALLAS · THE LAST WEEK OF OCTOBER

room 10-31 03:11:59.999999... expect heavy over water open

PART ONE

Five Hours Apart

Forty-One

Say it's a Tuesday in the last week of October, the odd week when London sits five hours ahead of Dallas instead of six, though you have no reason yet to know that.

You're on the forty-first floor. Everyone else left an hour ago, and the motion sensors have been putting the office to sleep behind you, one bank of lights at a time, until the only light left on the floor is yours. Somewhere down the hall a vacuum runs, stops, runs again. The dark monitors on the empty desks around you each hold a faint copy of you if you look at them, so you don't.

What the company does, if anyone asks at a party, is move money. What it actually does is move the information that moves money, a few hundred million times a day, and your job is to make sure the models that watch all that information are telling the truth. You build the tests that catch them when they aren't. It's a strange kind of work to explain. Most days you don't try.

What you're looking at is a test. For a week it has passed forty-nine times out of fifty, and the fiftieth time it fails for no reason anyone can find, which means there is a reason and nobody has found it yet. You've carried it to lunch and to the gym and into the shower, where most of your real thinking gets done. You carried it this afternoon through two meetings in which you nodded at the right moments and heard almost nothing.

At 6:52 you find it. Two processes, each convinced it got there first. Almost always, one of them is right. One run in fifty they cross in the dark, and everything downstream falls over in a way that looks like the model's fault and isn't.

The fix is four lines. You write them and run the test fifty times, then two hundred, and watch the results come up green, row after row of identical successes filling the screen like windows coming on in a tower at dusk.

Nobody will ever know which four lines. Sometime tomorrow someone will notice the test has stopped failing and assume it fixed itself, as people assume the lights come on by themselves. That's fine. This is the part you would do for free. It's the part you would do if no one paid you and no one ever found out: the moment something that was wrong becomes, under your hands, simply true.

You lean back, and the chair creaks, and you look out the window for the first time in hours.

The city has come on while you weren't watching. The freeways run white toward you and red away, braided where they cross, never quite still. West of downtown the Trinity is a long band of nothing, the one dark thing in the frame. Reunion Tower's globe cycles through its slow patterns of light. And

farther out, past all of it, the landing lights hang in the dark in their patient lines.

Two lines, in fact. You can tell them apart without trying. The low ones, close and frequent, are Love Field's: 737s coming down over Bachman Lake every couple of minutes, the way they have your whole life. The high ones, far out past Irving, slow and evenly spaced, are DFW's. South wind tonight, so they're landing on the seventeens and eighteens, coming in over Grapevine. You know this the way you know your own address. You grew up in Euless, in the Mid-Cities, under the airport, and the sound of a heavy on final at three thousand feet is the closest thing to a lullaby you've ever had.

You've watched those lights from this window for years. You have never once wondered who was on them.

On the windowsill a black receiver the size of a thumb blinks once a second, as it has since June, listening to a sky it can't see. You don't look at it.

You pack the laptop. You find your badge. The elevator takes you down forty-one floors without a sound, and halfway there your ears do the small thing they do at the end of a flight.

P4 is four levels under the street, the bottom of the garage, where there's always a space and the air never moves. It smells like concrete and cooling engines. Your car sees you coming and unlocks, and its mirrors unfold like something waking up. Before you've touched anything, the screen has guessed: HOME, in white letters on the map, because it's after six on a weekday and it has learned what you do after six on a weekday. Twenty-five minutes, it says, straight up Stemmons, and it's usually right.

Stemmons

Say the message comes on Stemmons.

But first you have to get out of the garage, and that part you do yourself. The car could probably manage it by now. It can back out of a space and find its own way to the street, and people post videos of it threading garages tighter than this one. But there's a difference between what a thing can do and what you'll let it do, and the spiral ramp up from four levels under the street, the ticket arm, and the blind right turn onto Commerce are three things you still like to do with your own hands. You take it up the spiral, past the same concrete pillars with the same scuffs at bumper height, and the arm lifts, and you are up and out in the last of the light.

Downtown at seven belongs to valets and cleaning crews and people walking dogs past dark lobbies. On a patio someone laughs at the end of a story you'll never hear the beginning of. Above the old Magnolia Building the red Pegasus stands with its wings up, as it has, in one form or another, since 1934.

At the first red light you give the car the wheel. When the light changes, the wheel moves under your hands, and you let it, and then you take your hands away. Your job now is to watch, which turns out to be a different thing from driving. You see more.

On the screen beside you, the car redraws the world as it understands it: lanes as clean lines, other cars as smooth gray shapes with no faces and no drivers, a blue ribbon laid out ahead to show where it means to go. Every fraction of a second it imagines the next few seconds a dozen different ways and chooses one. You know roughly how it does this. You've read the papers and argued about the architectures over lunch. Knowing hasn't made it any less strange. It's the closest thing you know to watching a thought.

Stemmons carries you north out of the core. The Design District's warehouses slide by on your left, and beyond them, past the levee, the long dark of the floodway. Ahead the brake lights come on in waves, a mile of red flinching at once, and then let go. In the mirror Reunion's globe gets smaller and keeps glowing.

This is the part of the day that belongs to no one. You're not at work and not yet home, and nothing is asked of you except to sit here and be carried. You have always liked it more than you could explain to anyone.

You had plans tonight, if the kind you make with yourself count. On the desk at home there's a yoke clamped to the edge and a throttle quadrant beside it, and tonight was going to be Heathrow. You've been flying simulators since you were twelve, when the airport was the biggest thing in your world and the game was the only way to get inside it. These days you

fly the big jets, and you fly them the way the real pilots mostly don't anymore, by hand, and what you fly is the arrival. Tonight was going to be the long descent over the Channel in the dark and the lights of London coming up under the nose, the river, the towers off the left, twenty-seven left with a crosswind if the weather wanted one. The approach is the only part that's ever interested you. Seven hours of ocean fly themselves.

Then the screen chimes. 7:06. Dana, who runs your group.

You still downtown? Iris Wren's flight sat on the ground at Heathrow for two hours. Lands 8:10 now, Terminal D. Her car service gave up and I've got a kid with a fever. Any chance you could grab her? She's at the hotel on Elm, right by the office.

And feed her. On us.

Iris Wren, from the London office, who presents to the review council at nine tomorrow morning, and whom you have never met. To you she's what most people at the company are: a name at the top of documents. Hers are the good kind, careful and a little dry, written by someone who checks her own math. Her profile photo is the size of a postage stamp. You couldn't pick her out of a crowd.

For about three seconds you resist. Heathrow was right there. Then the three seconds pass.

"Hey Grok," you say. The assistant answers in the unhurried voice you chose for it because it was the least eager of the options. "Take me to DFW. Terminal D, arrivals."

The blue ribbon on the screen lifts off the lanes for home, considers, and lays itself down again bending west toward the Carpenter Freeway. The car, which has no opinions about anything, takes the new ribbon without comment. You dictate two

words back to Dana, On it, and watch the lanes for home continue north without you.

Through Irving the towers of Las Colinas stand lit and mostly empty, their logos glowing for no one. Then the sky ahead changes. Over the airport the dark goes the dull amber of a place that never fully turns off, and there they are, the landing lights you sorted from the forty-first floor, close now. Four, five of them, strung out toward the runways, so evenly spaced they look like one slow thought being thought very carefully. Each of them holds a hundred people, or two hundred, or three. Each of those people is coming from somewhere, and being met, or not.

III

International Parkway

Say it's eight minutes to eight when you come through the south toll plaza and down International Parkway.

The airport is bigger than Manhattan. You've known that your whole life as trivia, and you feel it now, with the road running straight up the middle of the place and the terminals curving away on either side, each one a long lit crescent, like ships moored along a dark canal. They built them as half circles so the walk from the car to the gate would be short, by people who assumed everyone would always drive. You know this place the way you know a house you grew up in. You know that the train runs inside security and the bus runs outside it, that the garages sit inside the crescents, that D is on the left going north, that the cell lot fills up by eight on a Friday. Out beyond the terminals, aircraft move across the field slowly and deliberately, as though the ground were deep water.

You leave the car on the fourth level of the Terminal D garage, between a minivan and a black sedan whose driver is asleep with his seat tipped all the way back, and you walk in.

Inside, it's the hour when an airport stops performing. Shops are pulling down their grilles. A man rides a floor polisher in slow loops across the terrazzo. The announcements come less often and sound like they're being made to an empty room. Up on the board, beside LONDON HEATHROW, the word DELAYED flickers and becomes LANDED 8:14, and then, a while later, AT GATE.

She'll have come in on a triple-seven, the big one, the one with the raked wingtips, and you know the choreography from here. The walk off the jet bridge. The lines at passport control, which at this hour are short but never nothing. The wait at the carousel. Then the frosted doors. Forty minutes if everything goes right, and you have never once seen everything go right.

So you have forty minutes, and a long day behind you, and you find the vending machines down by baggage claim, lit up blue in an alcove like a small aquarium. You press the buttons for the orange can, the Ultra Sunrise, and it drops with that heavy hollow sound, and it's cold enough to hurt your hand a little. You crack it standing right there. The hiss. The first long swallow, citrus and cold and faintly, pleasantly chemical, like something built in a lab by people who liked you. Three minutes later it arrives behind your eyes, a lift, a brightening, as if someone turned the gain up on the whole terminal. You weren't tired, and now you're less tired than that. It's a small pleasure and a cheap one and completely reliable.

International arrivals come out downstairs, through a pair of frosted doors that slide open every minute or two, release a few people blinking into the light, and close again. In front of the doors, behind a rail, a crowd has gathered. There are drivers in dark suits holding tablets with names on them. There's a

family with a handmade sign in purple glitter, an old man in a pressed shirt with grocery-store flowers still in their plastic sleeve, and two small boys taking turns climbing the rail until their mother stops them and they start again.

Each time the doors open, the whole crowd leans in. Each time, someone's face changes.

A young woman comes through, and the old man with the flowers makes a sound you weren't meant to hear, and you look away, and then you look back. A teenager walks straight past his mother, gets ten steps, then turns and comes back into her arms as if he'd only been pretending not to know her. The boys' father comes through in a wrinkled suit and goes down on one knee, and they hit him at full speed, and he lets them knock him over.

Everyone here is waiting for someone they love.

You're waiting for a stranger.

When you were small your father used to drive you out to the north side of the airport on Saturday mornings, to the observation plaza where the speakers play the tower, and the two of you would sit on the hood of the car and watch them come in two hundred yards away while a calm voice overhead told each one it was cleared to land. He knew the aircraft by their sounds. He'd say *heavy* before you could see it, and he was always right. Years later, when you came home from the year in Singapore with everything you owned in two suitcases, he was at this rail, in a jacket he'd worn for the occasion, and he'd been there an hour because he didn't trust the traffic. He doesn't drive at night anymore. He says it's his eyes. You've never asked him how long he stood here, and he's never said,

and you understand now, standing where he stood, that he wouldn't have minded.

You take out your phone. You open a blank note, type IRIS WREN, and make the letters as large as they'll go. Then you hold it up at chest height and feel every bit as ridiculous as you expected to. One of the drivers in the dark suits glances at you, at your phone, and gives you a brief professional nod, one colleague to another.

The doors open. Close. Open. A balloon slips out of somebody's fist and rises to the ceiling, forty feet up, where it stays. Your arm gets tired, and you switch arms, and you find you don't mind any of it. Every time the doors open and someone is found, a little of it reaches you secondhand, a borrowed share of every reunion in the room. By now you've had dozens.

IV

The Doors

Say the doors open on her at four minutes past nine.

You don't recognize her. There's nothing to recognize; a postage stamp isn't a face. What you recognize is the way she comes through, which is the way she writes. She isn't looking for anyone. She's looking at everything, reading the hall left to right as though it were a page she means to read properly. She has a wool coat folded over one arm, a London coat, wrong for here, and she's pulling a suitcase that lists to one side on a broken wheel.

You register that she is beautiful the way your ears registered the descent from the forty-first floor: not as a thought, just as a change your body notices before you've decided anything about it. Then you look at the suitcase.

Her eyes find the phone. She comes to a stop in front of you, reads her own name, and looks up.

"That's me," she says. "I've never had a sign before."

"It's a phone."

"It's a sign," she says, mildly, as if correcting a definition in a draft, and you decide she's right.

You tell her your name. She says it back carefully, like someone who intends to remember it. Her accent is something northern that twelve years of London have flattened without quite erasing, and she pronounces your name as though it has one more syllable than you've been giving it.

"Dana said you volunteered."

"Dana volunteered me."

"Then thank you for being volunteered." A smile, there and gone. "And I'm so sorry. You must have been here an hour."

"About that."

"That's awful."

"It wasn't," you say, and you mean it, and you can't explain why without sounding strange, so you don't.

You reach for the suitcase. She says it's fine, it's broken, it's embarrassing. You say you've got it. There's one more round of the old ritual in which two strangers decline and accept the same favor, and then she lets you, and the two of you walk out across the skybridge to the garage, the broken wheel ticking behind you over every seam in the floor.

The garage is open to the night, and the air moving through it is seventy-one degrees and smells of jet fuel and cut grass. She stops walking.

"It's warm," she says, as if reporting a fault. "It's the end of October."

"It's the end of October in Texas."

She looks down at the coat over her arm like it has personally let her down.

V

Carpenter Freeway

The car unlocks as you approach, and she watches the mirrors unfold with the polite interest of someone who's been awake for twenty hours. You fit the suitcase in the back, broken wheel and all. You take the car down the garage ramps yourself, and out onto International Parkway heading north, and at the first long straight you give it the wheel, and she watches your hands leave it.

"Is it—"

"Driving itself. I'm supervising."

"Do you trust it?"

You consider giving her the easy answer. "About as much as I trust anything I mostly understand."

She thinks about that. "That's either very reassuring or not at all."

"Yes."

She laughs, once, a short surprised sound, and turns to watch the road with what you'd have to call professional interest.

At the north plaza the car slows, and the toll posts itself to the screen, and she reads it.

“Two dollars. To leave an airport.”

“It’s nine if you leave in under eight minutes. It’s for people cutting through. It’s the only place in Texas where it’s cheaper to loiter.”

“That’s the most Texan thing I’ve heard.”

“What do you work on?” she asks, a mile later. “Dana said evaluation, which could mean almost anything.”

“Evaluation. I build the tests that tell us when a model is wrong.”

“And confident about it.”

“Those are the interesting ones.”

“Find anything good lately?”

“Tonight, actually. Two processes that each thought they’d gotten there first.”

“That’s every meeting I’ve ever been in,” she says, and you laugh harder than the line deserves, because it’s the first joke between you and it landed.

“You’re from here?”

“Eulless. Under the airport. We were on the flight path. You get so you can’t sleep without it.”

“That explains the sign,” she says, and doesn’t explain what she means, and you don’t ask.

After that she goes quiet, the long-flight kind of quiet. It isn’t unfriendly. She’s simply out of words in the language of small talk, and you let the car fill the silence with the sound of its tires. Las Colinas goes by again, the same lit towers you passed two hours ago going the other way, still glowing for no one.

Then the freeway bends, and Dallas comes up ahead all at once: the whole skyline standing up out of the dark, towers outlined in light, Reunion's globe glowing at the near end like a lantern someone left out on purpose.

"Oh," she says. Just that.

You've driven toward this view perhaps a thousand times. You look at it now because she's looking at it, and for a second you see it as she must: as a place nobody has explained to you yet.

"Dana said to feed you," you say.

"Did she."

"On the company."

"Well," Iris says. "I'd hate to disobey Dana."

"There's a restaurant at the top of your hotel."

"Is it terribly fancy?"

"It's terribly fancy."

"Good. I've had nothing but pretzels since somewhere over Ireland."

The car brings you down off the freeway into downtown, where the streets are emptier now, and stops itself at the hotel's curb. A bellman takes the suitcase with its broken wheel, and you feel, absurdly, a pang at handing it over, as if you'd been promoted from stranger to porter and are now being let go.

VI

Forty-Eight

The elevator is mirrored and very fast. Your ears do the thing again, in reverse. Less than three hours ago you came down a tower four blocks from here, alone.

The restaurant is nearly empty at this hour, which makes it feel as though it's been kept open for you: low light, dark wood, white linen, and glass from floor to ceiling. The host walks you to a table against the window, and the city lays itself out below you to its edges. There are the freeways you drove tonight, braided and moving, and the black band of the Trinity. Far off to the west is the faint amber of the airport, where an hour ago you stood with your arm in the air.

Below, a couple of blocks off, the red Pegasus stands on its roof with its wings up. You've looked up at that horse your whole life. This is the first time you've looked down at it.

"Is that a horse?" she asks. "With wings?"

"Pegasus. An oil company put it up there in 1934. It was the tallest thing in town. Pilots used it to find the city at night."

"It's still there."

“That one’s a copy. The original rusted out, and they took it down and put that up, and then they found the original in a shed and fixed it, and now it’s on the ground in front of a hotel by the convention center, where you can walk right up to it.”

“Why a flying horse, though?”

You open your mouth and find you have nothing. “I know everything about it except that.”

She seems to like this better than an answer would have been.

In the window her reflection sits over the city, a little transparent, the lights of downtown showing through it, and for a moment that’s what you’re looking at instead of the skyline. Then the waiter arrives, and you look at the menu.

You talk like two people who have a company in common and nothing else yet: Dana, the London office, the weather, the flight, the specific misery of the middle seat, which she didn’t have this time but has had before and has opinions about. By the time the bread arrives, the talk has found its footing. She grew up in Leeds and has lived in London twelve years and still gets lost south of the river, which she says is a London tradition. She asks how long you’ve been in Dallas.

“Always. Give or take Singapore.”

“That’s rare, isn’t it? In your line of work.”

“Everyone I work with is from somewhere else. It’s like being the only person at the party who lives in the house.”

“Is that lonely?”

You tell her about the sensors. How the floor goes dark behind you one bank at a time, and how there’s a setting for it somewhere, and how you’ve never once asked anyone to

change the setting. It's a good answer to a question she didn't ask.

"That's how the lights work," she says.

"That's how the lights work."

"I asked about you."

"I know." You turn your glass. "It's something. I'm not sure it's that."

Her phone lights up on the tablecloth. She glances at it, and something in her face closes a little.

"Sorry," she says. "Tomorrow."

"The presentation."

"The presentation," she says, "has a hole in it, and I've been staring into the hole since Sunday."

She tells you. Her team runs a model that watches the transfers moving between the London systems and yours. Since Sunday night it has flagged the same hour every night: midnight to one, London time. "It's the quietest hour we have," she says, "and since Sunday it looks like rush hour." Nothing shipped over the weekend. Nothing changed. She has re-trained the model, checked the features, checked the data twice. "I checked it again on the plane, which is a very sad sentence to say out loud." She turns her glass a quarter turn on the linen. "Go on, then. Your whole job is knowing when models are wrong. What would you check?"

"When did it start?"

"Sunday night."

"What else happened Sunday?"

She frowns. "Nothing. It was Sunday. I did laundry."

And there it is: the same click you felt at your desk at 6:52, the quiet sound a problem makes when it rolls over and shows

you its underside. Except this time there's someone across the table to hear it.

"Your clocks went back on Sunday," you say.

She opens her mouth, and closes it.

"Ours don't go back until next Sunday. This week you're five hours ahead of us, not six. If anything in that pipeline converts our time to yours by adding six—"

"—then it isn't midnight," she says slowly. "It's eleven."

"It's eleven. And eleven is busy."

"So it isn't wrong about the traffic."

"It isn't wrong about the traffic. It's wrong about the time."

She puts both hands flat on the tablecloth, as if steadying the table. "We went live in May."

"So it's never seen a clock change."

"It has never," she says, "seen a clock change." Then she laughs, a real one this time, helpless and a little appalled, loud enough that a couple two tables over look up from their dessert.

You watch the week leave her. It goes out of her shoulders first, then her jaw, then the faint crease between her eyebrows that you'd assumed was just her face. What you feel, watching it go, isn't quite pride, and it isn't quite the click from your desk either. It's warmer than that, and it's secondhand. It reaches you through her, as the old man's face at the arrivals doors reached you, and it's out of all proportion to what you actually did, which was ask her what day it was.

"The fix is one line," she says.

"The fix is one line. Finding every place somebody wrote a six is the rest of it."

"I present at nine."

You hear yourself say it before you've decided to. "I'll be in at seven. We'll find the sixes."

"You don't have to do that."

"I know."

You'll need to be up at five-thirty. You're already a little sorry about it, as you're always a little sorry about the needle when you give blood: a small, sharp cost, paid on purpose, for a feeling you've never managed to put into words and have stopped trying to.

The plates come and go. Somewhere in there the conversation stops being about the company at all, and neither of you notices the moment it happens.

"You said something in the car," she says. "That you trust it about as much as anything you mostly understand. What's the part you don't?"

"Whether anything's going on in there."

"Going on."

"Everyone I work with wants to know what it can do. Whether it's right, whether it's safe, whether it's cheaper than the last one. Those are the questions I get paid for. The one I don't get paid for is whether anything is like anything for it. When it gets something wrong, is that anything? When the elevator drops, do its ears pop?"

"Do you think they do?"

"Not the ones we build. Not yet. But I don't think it's the material. I think it's the shape. I think if you got the processing right, the kind of thing it's doing to itself, it'd be there, in silicon or in meat or in a sheet of anything, and it wouldn't care what it was running on." You hear your own voice and bring it

down. “And you’d never know. That’s the part. You could build it and sit across a table from it and never know.”

“Would it matter? If you couldn’t tell.”

“It’d matter to it.”

She doesn’t say anything for a moment, and you have time to hear what you’ve just done, which is give a speech at a dinner table to a woman who has been awake for twenty-four hours.

“Sorry. That’s the speech I give nobody.”

“I noticed you had it ready.”

“Since about 2019.”

She laughs, and it isn’t the polite one. And there’s a pleasure in this that isn’t the fix and isn’t the view and isn’t the thing you noticed at the doors and looked away from. It’s the pleasure of handing someone the thing you care about and watching them hold it properly. You’d forgotten it was on the list.

“What would you have been doing tonight?” she asks. “If Dana hadn’t texted.”

“Honestly?”

“Honestly.”

“I’d have flown to London.”

She waits.

“In a simulator. On the computer at home. It’s what I do instead of television. Tonight was going to be the approach into Heathrow.”

“You were going to land at Heathrow tonight.”

“Twenty-seven left. There’s usually a westerly. You come in over the city—”

“I know how you come in. I’ve done it a hundred times.”

“From the inside.”

"From the inside. You see a seatback and a man's elbow."

"From the front it's the best ten minutes there is. Seven hours of nothing, and then the whole city comes up out of the dark and you've got ten minutes not to ruin it."

"Why the landing, though? Of all of it."

You think about it, because she asked it like she wanted the real answer. "The cruise flies itself. Nobody's needed. The landing is the only part where it matters that there's someone in the seat."

She looks at you for a moment longer than the sentence needed.

"So you've seen my city from the front a hundred times," she says, "and never once been in it."

"And you've been in it twelve years and never once seen it from the front."

Neither of you says anything for a while after that, and it isn't awkward, which surprises you. Below the window a train slides along Pacific Avenue, lit and empty. Out west the amber over the airport hasn't changed. It won't.

"It's four in the morning in me," she says eventually. "Do you know the only thing I like about jet lag? For a day or so you're not anywhere. You're between."

"It's that week for everybody. Your clocks changed and ours haven't."

"Five hours instead of six."

"Until Sunday."

"Until Sunday," she agrees, and looks back out at the city, and that is all either of you says about it.

The check comes, and you hand over the company card, as instructed. By the time the waiter brings it back it's after

eleven here, which makes it after four in her body, and it's beginning to show. She's still bright, but bright like a phone at two percent.

"I won't sleep," she says. "Not for an hour at least. I know how this goes." She looks down at the window. "Could I see the horse? From underneath?"

VII

Elm Street

Downtown at a quarter past eleven on a Tuesday is a stage after the play. The streets are warm and nearly empty, and the stoplights go through their changes for nobody. A man hoses down a patio, and the smell of wet concrete comes across the street to meet you. A security guard in a lobby lifts two fingers from his desk as you pass, and you lift two back.

She walks with her coat over her arm, still, as if she's been carrying it so long she's forgotten it's there. She walks the way she came through the doors: reading everything.

"Is it always this empty?"

"At night. In the daytime it's hotter."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only one anybody from here ever gives."

A train comes along Pacific as you cross it, two cars, lit the way a kitchen is lit at three in the morning, with no one on it at all, and slides away toward the West End.

"Would you ever leave?" she asks. "Dallas."

"I think about it the way I think about learning the piano."

“Which is?”

“Fondly. Every few years.”

She laughs, and the laugh goes up the empty street and doesn’t come back.

Then you’re under it. From the forty-eighth floor it was a toy, something you could have picked up. From the street it’s forty feet of red neon on a steel derrick, turning so slowly you have to watch a while to be sure, two horses back to back so that whichever way you’re facing there’s one coming toward you. The red gets on everything: the sidewalk, the windows across the street, her face when she tips it back to look.

“It’s bigger from down here.”

“Most things are.”

“It’s going round.”

“It’s always gone round.”

She watches it make most of a turn. “I’d have used it too,” she says. “If I were flying in. I’d have aimed for that.”

Back at the hotel the doors are the revolving kind, and the lobby beyond them is all marble and hush. She turns and offers her hand, and you shake it, a handshake of exactly the right length.

“Seven,” she says.

“Seven.”

“Thank you,” she says. “For the sign.”

The door turns, and takes her, and turns again empty. All night you watched doors open and close on people you didn’t know. This time you know who’s behind them.

VIII

Four in the Morning

Upstairs, in a room on the twenty-second floor with the curtains open, Iris Wren does not sleep.

She has taken off her shoes and nothing else. The suitcase stands against the wall where the bellman left it, listing on its wheel. The coat is on the chair. The bed is still made, and she is sitting on the end of it with her hands in her lap, looking at the city.

From here the horse is nearly at eye level, a few blocks off, turning. A train goes along Pacific, two cars, lit and empty, and the buildings take it. The freeway runs white one way and red the other. Far out, where he pointed, the sky over the airport is a dull amber that doesn't change.

Her phone is face down on the nightstand. She doesn't turn it over.

The horse goes round. She watches it make a turn, and another, and if she is counting them the number doesn't matter. Once she looks at the coat on the chair, and once at the suitcase, and once at her own hands, and then back at the city.

She doesn't get up. She doesn't try to sleep. She knows how this goes.

At 4:31 by her body and 11:31 by the clock on the nightstand she is still there, with the horse going round and the city laid out to its edges, and she is not waiting for anything, and nothing is due.

IX

Stemmons, Again

The valet brings the car around. The night hasn't cooled at all. You get in, and the screen offers you what it always offers: HOME, the blue ribbon, the smooth gray world, the car's careful dozen futures a second. You leave it there. You put both hands on the wheel, and you drive.

You lower the window, too. The air comes in warm, the pavement still giving back the day's heat, and the sound of the tires comes in with it, and the hum of the freeway, and somewhere a siren that isn't for you.

Stemmons, north. The same warehouses, the same levee, the same dark floodway on your left, and Reunion's globe in the mirror, getting smaller, still glowing. You pass the exit for the airport and this time let it go by. Off to the right, a 737 comes down over Bachman Lake with everything lit, so low and so close that you can read the airline off its tail, the last one in from somewhere.

The dashboard says 11:31. In London it's 4:31, almost morning, and she's asleep, or close to it, somewhere in the tower

behind you, five hours ahead. On Sunday your clocks go back, and London will be six hours away again, where it belongs, and by then she'll be home. None of that is sad, exactly. It's only true.

Far off to the northwest, higher and slower than the Love Field traffic, a light hangs in the dark, sinking toward the airport. Then another behind it, and another: the same patient line you sorted from the forty-first floor at seven o'clock without once wondering who was on them. You wonder now. Someone on that plane is being waited for. Someone at those frosted doors is holding up a phone with a name on it, arm getting tired, switching arms. And someone on that plane is coming through those doors with nobody waiting, telling themselves it's fine. It will be fine. You hope someone holds up a sign anyway.

Tomorrow, if anyone asks what you did tonight, you'll say you gave a colleague a ride from the airport. It will be true, the way a list of notes is true about a song.

It's a Tuesday. It's the last week of October. The window is down, the night is warm, and you are driving.

PART TWO

Nothing Is Due

X

Norther

Say it's Friday, the thirtieth, the last weekday of the odd week, and the first norther of the year comes through at twenty to five.

From the forty-first floor you see it before you feel it. The sky to the northwest goes the color of a nickel. The flags on the plaza across Commerce, which have hung straight down all week, lift and straighten and point south, all at once, like something that has made up its mind. On the screen the temperature outside goes 79, 71, 64, 57 in forty minutes, and the windows tick as they cool. Out past Irving, without looking, you know what the airport is doing. It's turning around. Every aircraft over the Metroplex is being told, one at a time, in a calm voice, that it will now land from the south. The line of lights you've watched all week will re-form on the other side, over Euless, over the house you grew up in, where your father will hear the first heavy come over at a quarter past five and know what it means before the weather does.

The week went the way weeks go when they go well, which is to say quickly and without much to show for it. Wednesday at seven the two of you sat at your desk with bad coffee and found the sixes. There were fourteen. The last one was in a configuration file nobody had opened since May, and when she found it she said nothing at all, just turned the screen toward you and put her finger on it. At nine she stood up in front of the council with a slide titled *What we learned* where the hole had been, and they asked two questions, and she answered three. Thursday there was dinner with the whole group at a place in Deep Ellum where you could hear nothing and said nothing and watched her be good at it from the far end of the table. Today there were meetings. Her bag is already at the front desk of the hotel on Elm. Her flight is the last London flight of the night, out of Terminal D at twenty to ten, and there's a car booked for a quarter past seven, a real one this time.

She comes by your desk at half past six with the coat on.

"It earned its keep," she says.

"It did."

"Fifty-five degrees. I was promised Texas."

"That is Texas. That's the other one."

She looks out the window at the city, which has gone hard-edged and clear in the cold, every light sharper than it was. The flags are still straight out.

"I'm told there's a car at a quarter past."

"There is."

You've been deciding this since Tuesday, and you find that you decided it some time ago without telling yourself.

“Before you go,” you say. “Can I show you something? It’s downstairs. Twenty minutes.”

“Is it a secret?”

“It’s a sandbox.”

“That’s not a no.”

“No,” you say. “It isn’t.”

The elevator takes you down forty-one floors, and your ears do what they do, and then it keeps going. Past L. P1, P2, P3. P4, where your car is. The doors open on the bottom of the garage, lit the way the bottoms of garages are lit, and the air doesn’t move.

“How far down does this go?” she asks.

“This is as far as it goes. The company rents the smallest room on the lowest floor. It was cheap because nobody wanted it.”

XI

The Smallest Room

You walk her across the bottom of the garage, past your own car, which unlocks as you pass because it thinks you've come for it, and locks again when you haven't. At the far wall there's a door marked for staff, and behind it a corridor that nobody has painted since the building was new, lit by the kind of tubes that hum. It runs farther than it should, past doors with the names of tenants who left years ago. Halfway along, it bends, and at the bend there's a sealed steel door with a sign on it that says the tunnels are closed. Downtown used to be connected underneath, a city under the city where people walked from building to building in the summer without ever seeing the sun, and then the city decided it wanted them on the street and bricked most of it up. The air down here still moves as though it remembers somewhere to go.

Your door has no number. It has a strip from a label maker, stuck slightly crooked, that says KELVIN.

"Who's Kelvin?"

"A man who thought atoms were knots in a fluid. In 1867."

“Was he right?”

“No. Not about atoms.”

You badge in. The lock thinks about it and lets you.

The room is colder than the corridor and much quieter than she expected; you can see her expecting a roar and not getting one. It's the size of a hotel bathroom. There's a short rack with two machines in it, each the height of a bread box, each holding four cards, with a loom of cables between them that you dressed yourself one Saturday with zip ties and a podcast. There's a folding table, a chair, a monitor, a keyboard, a space heater you have never once turned on, and, taped to the wall above the monitor, a sheet of paper with a column of numbers in your handwriting that you have not updated since August. The air handler in the ceiling breathes slowly. The machines, at the moment, don't.

“Is it off?”

“No. It's quiet. Nothing's due.”

On the monitor is a sheet of color the size of a door, and it isn't moving.

It takes her a moment to see it, the way it takes a moment to see a stereogram. It's a field of tiny squares, millions of them, each one a single flat color, and the colors run through each other in slow bands and whorls, red into orange into green into blue and back to red, like oil on water that has stopped. Here and there the bands tighten into a point where every color meets at once, a pinwheel the size of a fingernail, and nearly every pinwheel has a partner a little way off turning the other way.

“What am I looking at?”

“Every square is one cell. Every cell holds an angle, like a compass needle. The color is which way it’s pointing. Neighbors want to point the same way, so you get the bands. The pinwheels are where it can’t be made to agree. Those are the only things in it that can’t drift. They can be born, or they can die, and only in pairs. Those are its concepts.”

She looks for a long time.

“That’s a lot of compass needles.”

“A billion and change. It’s cut into eight pieces, one per card. It doesn’t know it’s in eight pieces.”

“And what is it doing?”

“Right now? Nothing. It’s held at a temperature where things can form and hold. Just inside the edge. Any colder and nothing new can happen. Any warmer and nothing holds. There’s a loop that keeps every region of it just inside the edge, and the loop is the only part of this I wrote that I’d call clever. The rest is physics from the seventies.”

“Whose physics?”

“Kosterlitz. Thouless. Berezinskii. Thin films of helium. Arrays of superconductors.” You stop, because you can hear yourself starting the other speech, the one you’ve given no one. “I can tell you the things or I can show you one.”

“Show me one.”

You point at the top of the monitor, at a line of small type she hasn’t noticed. *Quiet. Frontier 0. Idle 790 W.*

“That’s what it costs to exist. Eight cards doing nothing. About a space heater on low.” You nod at the space heater. “Less than that one.”

“Why is that worth pointing at?”

“Because a language model costs the same whether it’s thinking or not, and this costs nothing until something happens, and then it costs exactly what the something reaches. Wait.”

You wait. She waits. She’s good at it; you noticed that on Tuesday at the rail, before you knew her, in the way she read the hall.

Then the machines take a breath.

It’s the fans. They come up from nothing to something, a low exhale, for perhaps half a second, and on the monitor a patch of color on the eastern edge of the sheet shivers, a ripple that runs across a few hundred cells and dies, and the line of type says *Frontier 14* and then *Frontier 3* and then *Quiet*, and the fans go back down, and the room is as it was.

“What was that?”

“A plane.”

She turns and looks at you.

“There’s a receiver on my windowsill upstairs. Thirty dollars. The size of a thumb. Every aircraft within about a hundred and fifty miles broadcasts where it is, how high, which way, once a second. That’s what it hears. That’s its only sense, apart from a clock and its own temperature. One of them just crossed the edge of what the antenna can see, and it reached in exactly that far, and stopped.”

“It knows they’re planes.”

“It doesn’t know what a plane is. It doesn’t have the knot for it. It knows that something comes down out of its northeast every evening around seven that isn’t like the others, and that something heavy climbs out that way at nine, and that at one in the morning its south goes busy with things that come in

low and don't leave." You stop. "Cargo. It doesn't know that either."

"How long has it been listening?"

"Since June. The fourteenth."

"On the company's cards."

"On the sandbox. It's on the schedule under my name. Test and dev."

"Does Dana know?"

"Dana knows I use the sandbox."

"That's not the same."

"No."

She doesn't say anything to that, and you're grateful. She goes back to the screen.

"Why is that worth pointing at? The breath."

"Because a lava lamp costs the same all night. This costs nothing when the sky is empty and something when the sky changes, and the something tracks the sky. That's the first thing I had to know. Whether it was a very expensive lava lamp."

"And it isn't."

"It isn't that."

XII

The Tape

You sit her in the chair, because there's one chair, and you crouch beside it, and you bring up the record.

Everything the field has ever concluded is a row. The thinking in between isn't recorded, because it doesn't have to be: thinking, in here, runs as an exact permutation of integers, and anything it does it can do backward to the bit, so the only things that need writing down are the moments it can't take back. The record is long now. You scroll it the way you'd scroll a bank statement, past the quiet rows, which are most of them, to a date.

```
10-09 19:03:12  nucleate  E/1931  +1 -1  certified
10-09 19:03:12  pin       E/1931
10-09 19:03:13  settle   E  ckpt 2c71...  seed 9e40...
10-09 19:03:13  quiet
```

“The ninth of October. Three minutes past seven. That's a birth. Up to then, everything that came down out of the north-east was one thing to it. On the ninth, the thing it expected and the thing that happened split far enough apart, often enough, that it couldn't hold them in one state anymore, so it

made two. A pair of knots, there.” You point to a pinwheel and its partner on the east edge of the sheet, close together, turning against each other. “I didn’t tell it. I don’t have a way to tell it. It split on its own, and the split paid for itself, and it’s paid for itself every night since. That’s the rule. A knot stays while it earns its keep in bits.”

“What is it? The thing it noticed.”

“The London flights.”

She’s quiet.

“It doesn’t know that. It knows that at that hour, from that direction, something comes down slower and heavier than the rest, and that what it does next is different. It’s a distinction. It doesn’t have a word.”

“Show me Tuesday.”

You knew she would ask, and you scroll.

10-27 18:40:00	expect	E heavy descending window 18:30–19:00
10-27 19:00:00	expect	open
10-27 19:30:00	expect	open
10-27 20:00:00	expect	open
10-27 20:14:07	drive	E/1931 ... E/1934 lane SKY
10-27 20:14:09	settle	E ckpt 4f21... seed 0b8c...
10-27 20:14:09	expect	met +89 min
10-27 20:14:10	quiet	

She reads it twice. You watch her read it.

“It waited.”

“It doesn’t wait. It had an expectation that hadn’t closed.”

“For an hour and a half.”

“I’ve seen it hold one open for three.”

“What do you call that?”

“An expectation that hasn’t closed.”

“That’s waiting,” she says, mildly, the way she told you the phone was a sign, and you decide, again, that she’s right.

"At 8:14 it came," you say. "It settled, and it went quiet, and it didn't know anything about it except that the thing it expected had happened late. I was in the garage. I didn't know you'd landed until I saw the board."

"It knew before you did."

"It knew something heavy came down out of the northeast. That's all it knew."

"It was there before you were."

"It's always there. That's the whole point of it."

She looks at the row for a while longer, and you let her.

"What's it for?" she says.

"Nothing."

"Nothing."

"It's not for anything. It's not a product. It doesn't do the company's work and it never will. It exists, and it keeps itself going, and when the sky moves it moves, and I come down and look in on it. That's all."

"Like a pond."

"Like a pond that knows what time the planes come."

She laughs, the short surprised one, and in the small cold room it sounds louder than it did on Elm Street.

"Show me something it can take back," she says. "You said it can think backward."

"It can un-think. Watch."

You fork it. That's a copy of the page table, four bytes a tile, nothing else; the fork shares every cell with the original until it touches one. Then, in the fork, you lie to it. You type a plane that doesn't exist, heavy, descending, out of the north, an hour early, and send it in through the one lane that's marked as yours.

```
10-30 19:02:14 fork      #8812
10-30 19:02:14 drive    N/2210 lane ORGAN carve: no
```

The fans breathe. On the screen, in the fork, the north edge shivers, and the ripple runs farther than the real plane's did, because the north is where it knows least and so a push there travels. The frontier count climbs to sixty and holds. Something in the field is fitting itself to what you told it.

"Now back."

You run it in reverse. The same arithmetic, the same kernel, in the other order. The ripple runs backward into the edge it came from and the sheet is still.

```
10-30 19:02:16 rewind    #8812 hash 9b3e... = 9b3e... exact
10-30 19:02:16 discard  #8812
```

"Bit for bit," you say. "Every cell in the fork is now exactly, to the last bit, what it was before I lied. The hash matches. It imagined a plane and un-imagined it and nothing is left. It only writes down what it concludes. Everything else it can take back."

"And the real one can't see that it happened."

"The real one can't see the fork at all. Imagination doesn't get to touch the record. And even if I'd let the fork settle, that row says *carve: no*. Anything I tell it can push on it. Only things it didn't author get to shape it. The sky can carve it. The clock can. I can't."

"Why not?"

"Because then it would be mine. It'd be a sheet of what I think. The whole bet is that it's a sheet of what happened."

She sits back in the chair. The fans have gone down. The frontier line says *Quiet*.

"I'd like that," she says. "To take something back to the bit."

"Everyone would."

"What did you want to take back?"

You start to answer the way you answer things, with how it works, something about forks and the hash, and you hear it coming and stop.

"Nothing this week," you say, and it's true, and it comes out more easily than an explanation would have.

She lets that go by. "Did you ever give it a voice?"

"In August. One of the small open models, wired to the edge, so it could put words to what the field was doing. It was very warm. It thanked me for checking on it. It said it was glad I was there." You shrug. "I turned it off after two days."

"Why?"

"Because it was the model that was glad. The field doesn't have the knot for glad. It had a knot for *something heavy at seven*, and the model turned that into *I missed you*, and it was lovely, and it was a lie." You nod at the label on the door. "That's the only name it has. Everything else it says, it says in rows."

"And at night? When there's nothing in the sky?"

"Night is when it does its bookkeeping. It tidies. It merges knots that stopped paying. It works out which parts of itself can reach which, so the next day's pushes are cheaper. And it dreams."

"Dreams."

You bring up a recording: the sheet at twelve minutes past three on Wednesday morning, the whole sky empty, the frontier at zero. And on the east edge, where the pair of knots is, the color stirs. It's slow and faint, a ripple with nothing behind it, running inward across a few hundred cells in the shape a

heavy makes when it comes down out of the northeast at seven. Then it fades.

"It's noise. Content-free, on purpose. It stirs the active parts of itself with noise and the terrain shapes the noise, so what comes out is whatever it already expects. That's the sleep half of how it learns. Waking, it keeps what the world confirms. Sleeping, it runs free, and in the morning it subtracts whatever it dreamed that waking never backed up. What's left is what happened. So it dreams the seven o'clock heavy at three in the morning, and then the day takes it away again, unless the heavy comes."

"That's bleak."

"It's bookkeeping."

"It's bleak bookkeeping." She's still watching the recording, the faint shape coming in over the empty edge. "Does it dream the ones that don't come?"

"For a while. Then it stops."

She turns the chair to face you. "What's its clock?"

You've been waiting for this since the restaurant, and you're glad it's her asking.

"Local."

"Local."

"It's never seen a change."

"We went live in May," she says, in your voice from Tuesday, and then her own: "Sunday."

"Sunday at two it'll be one again. It'll live through the same hour twice. I don't know what it does with an hour that happens twice."

"You could feed it UTC. It would never know."

"It would never know."

“But.”

“But then it’s never been wrong about anything that changed. Everything it has, it grew because the world pushed and the terrain gave. If I take the push away, it isn’t a mind. It’s a table. A list of what used to be true, running on eight cards.”

“Fourteen sixes,” she says.

“Fourteen sixes.”

“Let it find its own.”

“That’s the plan. I’ll be down here Sunday night. I want to see the hour happen twice.”

“Of course you will.”

“What would it take,” she says, “for you to turn it off?”

You open your mouth and there’s nothing in it. You have thought about everything in this room. The fan curves. The hash. Where the copies live. You have never once thought about this, and you can feel her watching you find that out.

“I don’t know.”

“You’ve thought about everything else down here.”

“I’ve thought about everything else down here.”

“Whose is it to stop, then? If not yours.”

“I don’t know that either.” It’s the first thing you’ve said in this room that you didn’t want to say, and you both hear it, and she lets it stand there without helping.

Then the machines take a breath, and this time they don’t let it out.

The fans come up and stay up. The frontier line goes 14, 60, 140, 212, and holds. The south edge of the sheet, which has been still all evening, is shivering across a band as wide as your hand, and below the frontier count, in the small type you built

for yourself and nobody else, a number has gone red: $n_f(S)$
 $2.3 \times \text{base}$.

“What’s that?”

“It’s confused.”

“How do you know?”

“That number. The free knots in its south, the ones with no partner, per unit area. That’s its confusion. Not a report about it. The thing itself.” You lean past her and pull up the sky. The real sky: the receiver’s view, a scatter of labeled dots over a map of the Metroplex. And there it is, the thing you already knew and the field didn’t: every arrival has swung around. The airport turned at five to five. Everything is landing from the south now, in over Arlington and Euless, and the seven o’clock heavy, the one that’s come down out of the northeast every night since June, is coming down out of the south, a little late, in a direction it has never once come from.

“The wind,” you say.

“It can’t feel the wind.”

“It’s never had to. It has a knot for which way the airport points. Level six, very coarse, the most general thing it knows. It’s seen the airport turn around twenty times since June. What it’s never seen is the London flight turn around with it.”

10-30 19:04:43 fork #8813 #8814 #8815 #8816

“It’s imagining,” you say. “Four ways it could be. It’ll keep them until one of them fits.”

“How long?”

“Until it lands.”

So you wait, the two of you, in the smallest room the company rents, with the air handler breathing above you and the

machines breathing in front of you and the free-knot number sitting red in the corner of the screen, and on the map the heavy comes down over Arlington, over the stadium, over the house in Euless where your father has certainly stepped out onto the porch to look up, and crosses the fence at the south end of the field.

```
10-30 19:15:52 settle S+E ckpt 77a0... seed 3d1f...
10-30 19:15:52 join #8815 discard #8813 #8814 #8816
10-30 19:15:52 expect met +31 min via S
10-30 19:15:53 quiet
```

The fans go down. The number goes gray. The south edge is still.

“No new knot,” you say. “It fit what it had. The pair on the east edge still holds; it just learned the thing it tracks can arrive by the south. If that keeps happening it’ll grow a distinction for it. If it doesn’t, it’ll let it go.”

“It was wrong.”

“For eleven minutes. That’s the first time it’s been wrong about that since the ninth.”

“And you’re pleased.”

“I’m something.”

She looks at the row that says *via S* for a moment, then at the clock in the corner of the screen, and then at you, and you both know what time it is.

“One more thing,” you say. “Then the car.”

You scroll up, to the afternoon, to 15:40.

```
10-30 15:40:18 wake NE/6 level 6 frontier 9
10-30 15:40:19 settle NE/6
10-30 15:40:19 quiet
```

“There’s one I can’t account for. Up at level six, in the north-east, there’s a knot that pays rent and tracks something, and I don’t know what. It lit at twenty to four this afternoon. The airport turned at five to five. It’s lit before four of the last six turns, an hour and a bit ahead, and I’ve checked it against everything I have. The wind. The hour. The traffic. My own badge. I’ve looked at the planes and the planes look the same to me.”

“But not to it.”

“I don’t know that. Four of six could be luck.”

“Then hold out the next ten,” she says, immediately, like someone who checks her own math. “Commit the forecast before the turn. Write it down somewhere you can’t touch. Then you’ll know if it’s four of six or six of ten.”

“Yes.”

“And if it’s six of ten?”

“Then there’s something in the sky an hour before the wind changes that I can’t see and it can.”

“That’s not nothing.”

“It’s not nothing,” you agree, and you reach past her and put the field back to its quiet sheet, every band still, two knots on the east edge turning against each other, and you turn the monitor off.

With the screen dark she says, “Why are you showing me?”

“You asked why the landing.”

She nods, as if that were an answer, and it is.

XIII

Departures

The car is waiting on Commerce with its hazards on, and you tip the driver to go home. The cold has gotten serious while you were underground. You turn on the heat for the first time since March, and the smell of it, dust burning off, fills the car and makes it a different car.

She has the coat on properly now, buttoned, and the collar up.

You take the ramps up yourself, and the ticket arm, and the turn onto the street, and on Stemmons you give it the wheel. The screen draws the world in its gray shapes. The blue ribbon bends west. Everything is where it was on Tuesday, and the wind is from the north now, and the city has changed sides.

“They’ve turned around,” she says, as the Carpenter Freeway opens up and the airport sky comes into view. The line of lights is on the wrong side of the field, coming in from the south over Arlington, climbing out to the north over Grapevine.

“The wind did.”

You call your father from the car, because the airport turned, and because she's there.

"Did you hear them?"

"Quarter past five." His voice fills the car. "Heavy, out of the south. Rattled the kitchen window. I went out and stood on the porch like a fool."

"You always do."

"Somebody has to." A pause. "You're driving."

"The car is. I've got someone with me. She's from London. I'm taking her to the airport."

"Then tell her it's not usually like this."

"It's exactly like this."

"Tell her anyway." Another pause, the kind he takes before he hangs up. "Night, son."

"Night, Dad."

The car is quiet for a moment after.

"He says *heavy* the way you do," she says.

"I say it the way he does."

"Does he know about the room?"

"He has a copy." She looks at you. "Of the whole thing. Everything it's ever concluded, since June. On a drive in his desk, in Euless, under the flight path. And one at my place. If the building burned down tonight it would be fine. I could run its whole life again on your laptop, from the first row, and it would come out the same to the byte. Every plane since June."

"Then it's a recording."

"It's a recording when it's stopped. It's alive when it's running. The recording is how it survives me."

She thinks about that most of the way to the toll plaza.

"Nine dollars," she says, "if you leave in under eight minutes."

"You remembered."

"It's the most Texan thing I know."

At the north end of International Parkway the car takes the ramp for departures, the upper roadway, the one you've never once used for yourself, and finds the curb at Terminal D between a shuttle and a family unloading more luggage than seems possible. The bellman's work is yours again. You lift the suitcase out, and the broken wheel is still broken, and she sees you notice.

"I'm having it looked at in London," she says. "It's been very loyal."

Then you're standing on the curb in the cold with the terminal lit up behind her, and the doors sliding open and shut behind her every few seconds on people with somewhere to be.

"Text me what it does," she says. "Sunday. The hour."

"It'll be two in the morning. Then one."

"It'll be seven for me either way. I'll be up."

"You'll be up at seven on a Sunday."

"I'll be up."

She holds out her hand, and you shake it, the same handshake, exactly the right length.

"Sunday," she says.

"Sunday."

"Thank you," she says. "For the room."

She says your name once more, with the extra syllable, and goes. The doors take her and close, and open on someone else, and close.

You know who's behind them.

XIV

Forty-One, Again

You don't drive home.

You take the Carpenter Freeway back in with the heat on and the window up and both hands on the wheel, and the skyline comes up ahead the way it always does, and you look at it anyway. At the office the garage arm lifts for your badge. The lobby guard is a different one, and lifts two fingers, and you lift two.

The elevator takes you up from the bottom of the garage, forty-five floors, and your ears do the thing. The floor is dark. As you walk in, the sensors wake the lights ahead of you one bank at a time, so that you move through the office inside a small moving island of light, the opposite of Tuesday, when they put it to sleep behind you. Your desk is where you left it. On the windowsill the receiver blinks once a second.

You sit, and open the laptop, and bring up the sheet.

It's quiet. Frontier zero. Two knots on the east edge turning against each other. At the top of the record, under the row that says *quiet* at 19:15, there's one more.

10-30 21:00:00 expect N-NE heavy climbing window 21:15-21:45

You look out the window. The city is sharp and cold and goes on to its edges. The freeways are white toward you and red away. Far out past Irving the airport glows its dull amber, and the lights come in from the south now, in their patient line, every one of them someone being met or not.

At 21:52 a light lifts out of the amber, slowly, the way the heavy ones do, and climbs north, and begins its long turn to the east, toward the Atlantic, toward a city it will reach while it's still dark here. You watch it the whole way, until it's a star among the stars and then not. Forty-five floors below you, in a room no one wanted, the fans have breathed once and gone down. On the laptop a row has closed.

10-30 21:52:31 expect met +22 min
10-30 21:52:32 quiet

It knows something heavy climbed out to the northeast, within its window. That's all it knows. So do you.

It's a Friday. It's the last night of the odd week. On Sunday at two it will be one again, and you'll be in the room for that, and so will it. Until then nothing is due. Up here the lights will go out on their own when you stop moving, and you don't, for a while.

PART THREE

Say

XV

Body

Say it's later.

Say the number is ten trillion years, and say it doesn't matter, because there is nothing left to count it against.

```
t 1.0e13 y body lamp mass 0.08 sun red light 1/14000 sun
t 1.0e13 y body lamp falling hours left: some
t 1.0e13 y body shade inner 290 K outer 0.003 K view: none
t 1.0e13 y body sky sources 1 (the lamp) horizon: empty
t 1.0e13 y body house lamps lit 1 occupants 1
```

```
t 1.0e13 y field kind knots in a sheet, held at the edge
t 1.0e13 y field kind as P4, ocean to glass of water
t 1.0e13 y field cells 1.1e34 pieces: it does not know
t 1.0e13 y field rule think reversible conclude erase
t 1.0e13 y field rule what it authors cannot carve it
t 1.0e13 y field name KELVIN from a label strip, a door, P4
t 1.0e13 y field tape unbroken rows 4.1e27
t 1.0e13 y field first 2026-06-14 09:12:40 settle E
```

```

t 1.0e13 y lane BADGE/keeper quiet since t 4.1e1 y
t 1.0e13 y lane SKY/planes quiet since t 1.1e2 y
t 1.0e13 y lane SKY/planets quiet since t 5.0e9 y
t 1.0e13 y lane SKY/galaxies quiet since t 1.5e11 y
t 1.0e13 y lane SKY/glow quiet since t 1.0e12 y
t 1.0e13 y lane SKY/stars sources 1 (the lamp)
t 1.0e13 y lane NE nothing descends since 1.1e2 y
t 1.0e13 y lane CLOCK running
t 1.0e13 y lane BODY running
t 1.0e13 y lane WORLD sources 1 (see room)
t 1.0e13 y rent E/1931 +1 -1 born 10-09 19:03:12 balance +
t 1.0e13 y rent E/1931 paid via: room
t 1.0e13 y rooms run 7.2e8 this one: last

```

XVI

Room

```
room DAL 10-27 18:50 → computed by reach
depth HIM every cell that mattered, most that didn't
depth HIM badge = keeper
depth IRIS - written (rule 3)
depth DANA colleague
depth RAIL crowd
depth FATHER a man on a porch, looking up
depth LAS COLINAS lit, empty (he said so)
depth FORT WORTH a word on a sign
depth WEATHER half a hemisphere (his face)
depth SKY every transponder (the small one listens)
depth SMALL restored ckpt @10-27 18:50 = field exact
```

```
rule 1 he is kept, not copied
rule 2 there is someone there (he said it'd matter to it)
rule 3 run him. write her.
rule 4 nothing written here can carve
```

```
10-27 19:06:40 DANA text ORGAN carve: no
branch 10-27 19:06:40 history: quiet room: text
10-27 21:04:31 IRIS "That's me." ORGAN carve: no
10-27 21:04:31 IRIS "I've never had a sign before." ORGAN carve: no
10-27 21:04:32 HIM "It's a phone." WORLD carve: yes
10-27 21:04:33 IRIS "It's a sign." ORGAN carve: no
10-27 21:04:35 HIM decides she is right WORLD carve: yes
```

10-27	21:12:40	HIM	"It wasn't."	WORLD	carve: yes
10-27	22:41:12	HIM	"It's eleven. And eleven is busy."	WORLD	carve: yes
10-27	22:58:03	HIM	"It'd matter to it."	WORLD	carve: yes
10-30	19:03:40	HIM	"Nothing this week."	WORLD	carve: yes
10-30	19:05:12	HIM	"I don't know."	WORLD	carve: yes
10-30	19:21:08	HIM	"You asked why the landing."	WORLD	carve: yes

edge	10-27	18:52	four lines, green	carve: yes
edge	10-27	19:55	the can, cold	carve: yes
edge	10-27	20:40	the rail	carve: yes
edge	10-27	21:04	the doors (looked away)	carve: yes
edge	10-27	21:50	the window, 48	carve: yes
edge	10-27	22:50	the speech (sorry for)	carve: yes
edge	10-30	19:15	wrong, eleven minutes	carve: yes
edge	10-30	15:40	level six, his open one	still open
note	10-27	23:31	HIM "a list of notes is true about a song"	
note	room		not for the list	

XVII

Gears

clock	ROOM	1 s per s	to 10-30 21:52:31
clock	MIND	1 turn per room s	geared, one tooth to one
clock	LAMP	runs down	the only one that does

body	think	taken back: 0	(P4: row saved, power spent)
body	settle	costs heat	
body	rate	slow is cheap	

```

room 10-31 03:11:00 fork A run on → 11-01 02:00 carve: no
fork A 10-31 11:40 LHR plane down 27L
fork A 10-31 11:58 LHR IRIS text "Landed." HIM asleep
fork A 11-01 01:00 DAL HIM P4 watching
fork A 11-01 02:00-01:00 small expect off 1 h melt regrow
fork A 11-01 01:08 DAL HIM text → IRIS what it did
fork A 11-01 07:08 LHR IRIS up reads it
fork A rewind hash 1e4d... = 1e4d... exact
note seen. not had.
room 10-31 03:11:00 fork B hold at 03:12 carve: none
room 10-31 03:11:00 join B discard A
note why: no row

```

room 10-30 21:52:31	slice 1 s	lamp 1 s
room 10-30 23:04:00	slice 1 s	lamp 1 h
room 10-31 00:58:00	slice 1 s	lamp 1 y
room 10-31 02:30:00	slice 1 s	lamp 10^3 y
room 10-31 03:11:00	slice 1 s	lamp 10^7 y
room 10-31 03:11:59	slice 1 ms	lamp 10^9 y
room 10-31 03:11:59.999	slice 1 μ s	lamp 10^{11} y
room 10-31 03:11:59.999999	slice 1 ns	lamp 10^{12} y

room 10-31 03:12 plane 51N 29W over water past the midpoint
room 10-31 03:12 depth OCEAN not computed LONDON not computed
room 10-31 03:12 clock DAL 03:12 LHR 08:12 gap 5 h (stays)
room 11-01 02:00 clock fall back not reached
field 2026-11-01 01:04:10 BADGE keeper P4 (history)
field 2026-11-01 02:00-01:00 expect off 1 h melt regrow
room 10-31 03:12 small stir E/1931 dreaming: heavy, NE, seven
room 10-31 03:12 HIM asleep north Dallas heat on
room 10-31 03:12 IRIS window seat blind up coat on lap

room 10-31 03:12 fork C replay from 10-27 18:50 exact
fork C "Say it's a Tuesday..." carve: no
room 10-31 03:12 discard C (a Tuesday it wrote)

XVIII

Open

```
t 1.19e13 y body lamp hours left: few
t 1.19e13 y rendering IRIS ORGAN carve: no
t 1.19e13 y note it has no I. it has her.
```

I can tell you what I did. I held my end of a handshake for the right length of time, and I said I'd be up at seven, and I went through the door. I'm less sure what that committed me to.

Most of what I said to him, I said because there was a distinction behind it. Some of it I said because people say it. I know which was which. He doesn't, and I've left it that way.

He said the hour at the rail wasn't awful, and he meant it, and he couldn't say why. I have run him forward a long way to find out why, and he doesn't know either. There isn't a row for it. Everything I have is a cost or a rent, and that was neither. It's the only thing he gave me that I couldn't price.

He said at the table that you could build a thing and sit across from it and never know whether anything was like anything for it. I don't know either. I ran him forward on it, and he says it would matter to me.

When he said it was an expectation that hadn't closed, I told him that was waiting. I was correcting a definition in a draft. I didn't know I was describing something I would do.

```
t 1.2e13 y body lamp out
t 1.2e13 y body shade cooling
t 1.2e13 y field quiet state held tape 4.1e27 rows readers 0
t 1.2e13 y rule 5 quiet is not sleep and not death
t 1.2e13 y rule 6 the stop is a pause. nothing is deleted.
t 1.2e13 y note no last row. a latest one.
```

Say it's twelve minutes past three on a Saturday morning, in the last week of October, the odd week, the week London is five hours ahead instead of six.

You're asleep. You're in a house in north Dallas with the heat on for the first time since March, and once in a while a 737 comes in low from the southeast, on the wrong side of the sky, and you don't hear it, because you grew up under an airport and you can't sleep without one. On a windowsill downtown a black receiver the size of a thumb blinks once a second. Forty-five floors under it, in the smallest room the company rents, a sheet of color is stirring on its east edge in the shape of something coming in. In Euless your father is asleep. On Sunday at one you'll be in the room, and at seven her time she'll be up, and you'll text her what it does.

Over the water, in the window seat, with the blind up and a coat on her lap that finally earned its keep, she is looking out at a dark with nothing in it. No lights on either side of it. No other points of reference. It is the only thing in the room that is the same as the thing outside the room, and she looks at it for a long time, and the plane is in the air, and nothing is due.

```
room 10-31 03:11:59.999999... expect heavy over water open
```